Program overview · 2025

GreenRoots Youth Corps

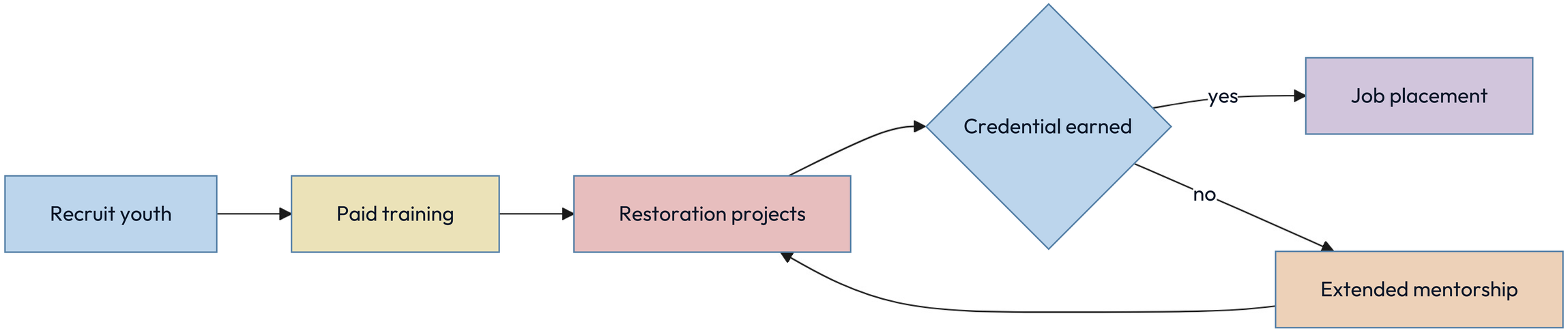
A paid pathway from the Cedar River banks to a green-collar career, for youth the labor market left behind.

We pay young people to restore the Cedar River — and train them into green jobs.

GreenRoots is a 16-week paid program for youth ages 16–24 in Cedar Rapids' East River neighborhoods. Crews restore habitat across the watershed while earning a wage, certifications, and a direct line to hiring partners.

- Participants earn $16/hour from their first day in the field.
- The work is real: erosion control, native planting, trail repair under contract.

Our theory of change, from intake to a green career.



A participant's path through the program.

STEP 01

Recruit

Outreach through high schools and reentry partners brings youth into a paid four-week orientation.

STEP 02

Train

Twelve weeks of field training in habitat restoration, chainsaw and first-aid certs, and job-readiness coaching.

STEP 03

Work

Crews complete real restoration contracts across the Cedar River watershed, earning a wage and a portfolio.

STEP 04

Place

Case managers match graduates to employer partners or post-secondary programs and check in for a year.

Outcomes · 2025

More youth enrolled, and more left with a job or a school seat.

240

Youth enrolled

UP FROM 180 ✓ +33% 2025

78%

Placed or in school

TARGET 70% ✓ ON PLAN

VERIFIED

91%

Credential earned

OF THOSE WHO FINISHED ✓ ON PLAN

AUDITED

Who we serve, and who delivers the program.

Youth participants — Ages 16–24

240 young people from the East River neighborhoods, paid $16/hr while they train.

Program staff — GreenRoots team

Eight crew leaders and two case managers run daily restoration work and aftercare.

Employer partners — 14 partners

Parks departments, utilities, and landscaping firms that hire our graduates directly.

> *I'd been kicked out of two schools before this. Out here I learned I could lead a crew. Now I run a parks team and I'm back in night classes.*

— DEVON REYES, 2025 GRADUATE, GREENROOTS YOUTH CORPS

The earnings story behind a placement

$18,600

average annual earnings for a placed graduate one year out — first steady income for most.

Impact · 2025

A single season of restoration, by the numbers.

240
YOUTH SERVED

78%
PLACED OR IN SCHOOL

38
WATERSHED ACRES RESTORED

14
HIRING PARTNERS

Recruitment reaches the young people other programs miss.

We draw enrollees from Cedar Rapids' three highest-unemployment neighborhoods. Two reentry organizations, the public library, and four high schools drive most qualified referrals into the program.

- 61% of the 240 enrollees came from those priority neighborhoods.
- 44% had a prior justice-system contact; 29% were not enrolled in school at intake.

The work itself is the curriculum.

Crews spend their days on contracted restoration — removing invasive honeysuckle, planting native buffers, and stabilizing eroded banks along the Cedar River. The wage and the certifications come from doing real work, not simulations.

- Field days are paired with two afternoons a week of certs and job-readiness coaching.
- Every graduate leaves with a portfolio of completed restoration sites.

Equity · 2025

The program reaches and keeps the youth it sets out to serve.

61%

From priority neighborhoods

OF 240 ENROLLED · ON PLAN · VERIFIED

44%

Prior justice contact

RE-ENGAGED THROUGH WORK

ON PLAN · TRACKED

83%

Completion rate

FINISHED ALL 16 WEEKS · ON PLAN

AUDITED

Cost · 2025

Public dollars stretch further than a year of incarceration.

All figures from audited spend over 240 enrollees and 187 placements.

$6,200
COST PER ENROLLEE

$7,950
COST PER PLACEMENT

84%
TO DIRECT SERVICES

16%
TO ADMINISTRATION

Two things ran harder than planned this year.

A spring flood closed three worksites for five weeks, compressing the field calendar. Our fall cohort enrolled 52 against a 70-seat plan after a bus-route cut stranded referrals.

- We recovered field hours by extending contracts into the dry early-winter weeks.
- A transit stipend restored the next cohort to full size.

The plan · 2026–2028

Where the next three seasons take the Corps.

WORKSTREAM	NOW 2025	BUILD 2026	SCALE 2027
Youth served	✓ 240	− 320	○ 450
Hiring partners	✓ 14	− 22	○ 30
Watersheds	✓ Cedar	− +Iowa River	○ +Wapsipinicon
Certifications	✓ 3	− +Arborist	○ +Water quality

✓ Shipped − In flight ○ Planned

We are ready to grow — and we are asking partners to grow with us.

The model holds: 240 youth served, 78% placed or in school, 84 cents of every dollar reaching participants. We are inviting funders and employers to help extend the Corps to a second watershed in 2026.

- A second site would add 80 paid seats and eight new hiring partners.
- Every expansion dollar is matched by contracted restoration revenue.

Tessa Moreno · Program Director · programs@greenrootscorps.example

Pay a young person to heal a river, and you get back both a watershed and a worker.